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COMMUNITY RELATIONS OPERATIONS · HIGHLAND STUDIOS

Approved:

User Generated Content & Modding Longevity Audit

A competitive analysis of UGC adoption rates, mod-driven retention multipliers, and long-tail player lifetime value extension across key genre comparators — drawn from FY2025 Steam Workshop data.

HEADLINE MULTIPLIER

3.4x

Average player lifetime value extension for titles supporting open modding vs locked-asset titles

PREPARED BY

Community Relations
Operations

DATA SET

FY2025 Steam Workshop
Scrapes

REFERENCE

CRO-UGC-2026-
FY25

CLASSIFICATION

Internal —
Restricted

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This audit analyses the impact of user-generated content (UGC) and community modding infrastructure on player retention and long-tail commercial performance across a sample of 34 titles active on Steam, covering the FY2025 measurement window. The sample includes simulation, action-sports, racing, survival crafting, RPG adventure, and strategy/management comparators so that UGC demand is evaluated as a market-wide retention mechanism rather than a feature attached to one genre.

Titles that support open modding demonstrate an average LTV extension of 3.4× compared to equivalent titles with locked asset structures. Within the simulation genre, the adoption floor is remarkably high — 72% of active simulation game players install at least one community mod within their first 90 days. Survival crafting and strategy/management titles show different but commercially meaningful patterns: players rely on private servers, scenario files, rulesets, and automation templates rather than only cosmetic asset packs. For action-sports titles with integrated park/track builder tools, community content maintains monthly active user counts at 40% of launch peaks a full twelve months post-release.

The audit also surfaces a critical risk profile: modding pipelines, if improperly architected, introduce security vulnerabilities and QA obligations. The LifeSpace project failure provides a detailed negative case study in this report. Implementation success requires deliberate technical planning and dedicated resourcing, but the commercial returns justify the investment at scale.

3.4×

Average LTV extension
for open-modding titles
vs locked-asset titles

72%

Simulation players who
install mods within 90
days of purchase

450K

Custom map downloads
on Streetline Skate 12
months post-launch

40%

MAU retention at month
12 for action-sports
titles with UGC tools

SECTION 01

Methodology: Steam Workshop Data Extraction & Scope

The data underpinning this audit was collected via structured scraping of Steam Workshop metadata, supplemented by Steam's publicly available achievement and review analytics. The scraping methodology was approved by the Community Relations Operations data governance committee and conducted in

compliance with Valve's public API terms of service. Where data required supplementary validation, cross-referencing was performed against SteamSpy public estimates and direct developer disclosures where available.

1.1 SAMPLE COMPOSITION

The FY2025 sample comprises 34 titles with Steam Workshop, mod hub, or first-party creator-tool integration, spanning six genre categories: simulation/life (n=10), action-sports/skateboarding (n=7), racing (n=5), survival crafting (n=5), RPG adventure (n=4), and strategy/management (n=3). Titles were selected using the following inclusion criteria: minimum 100,000 Steam owners at time of data collection, minimum 12 months post-launch, and active community-content presence with at least 500 published or indexed items.

For the control group comparison (locked-asset titles), a matched sample of 28 titles was assembled using equivalent owner-count, genre, and age criteria, excluding titles with any Workshop or modding infrastructure. Matching was conducted on launch-window review score, owner count at 30 days post-launch, and price point, to minimise confounding variables in the LTV multiplier calculation.

1.2 KEY METRICS DEFINED

METRIC	DEFINITION	DATA SOURCE
Player LTV (estimated)	Total estimated spend per player across base game, DLC, and in-game purchases over a 24-month window	Steam review cohort analysis + developer disclosures
Mod Adoption Rate	% of active players who have downloaded ≥1 mod item from Steam Workshop or equivalent	Steam Workshop API download counts vs owner estimates
MAU Retention Index	Monthly Active Users at month N as % of month-1 MAU (launch window peak)	Steam achievement unlock timing + review posting patterns
UGC Content Volume	Total number of unique Workshop items published by the community	Steam Workshop API
Organic Social Posts	Estimated social media posts referencing UGC/mod content, derived from hashtag volume data	Social listening panel (Pulse Analytics partnership)

SECTION 02

The UGC Retention Multiplier — Sector-Wide Analysis

An audit of top competitor games reveals that user-created assets and custom maps are the single largest drivers of long-tail player retention. Games that support open modding show an average player lifetime value extension of 3.4x compared to games with locked assets. This figure is remarkably consistent across the

simulation and action-sports genre clusters in our sample, suggesting the retention mechanism is a property of the modding infrastructure itself, rather than genre-specific audience behaviour.

3.4×

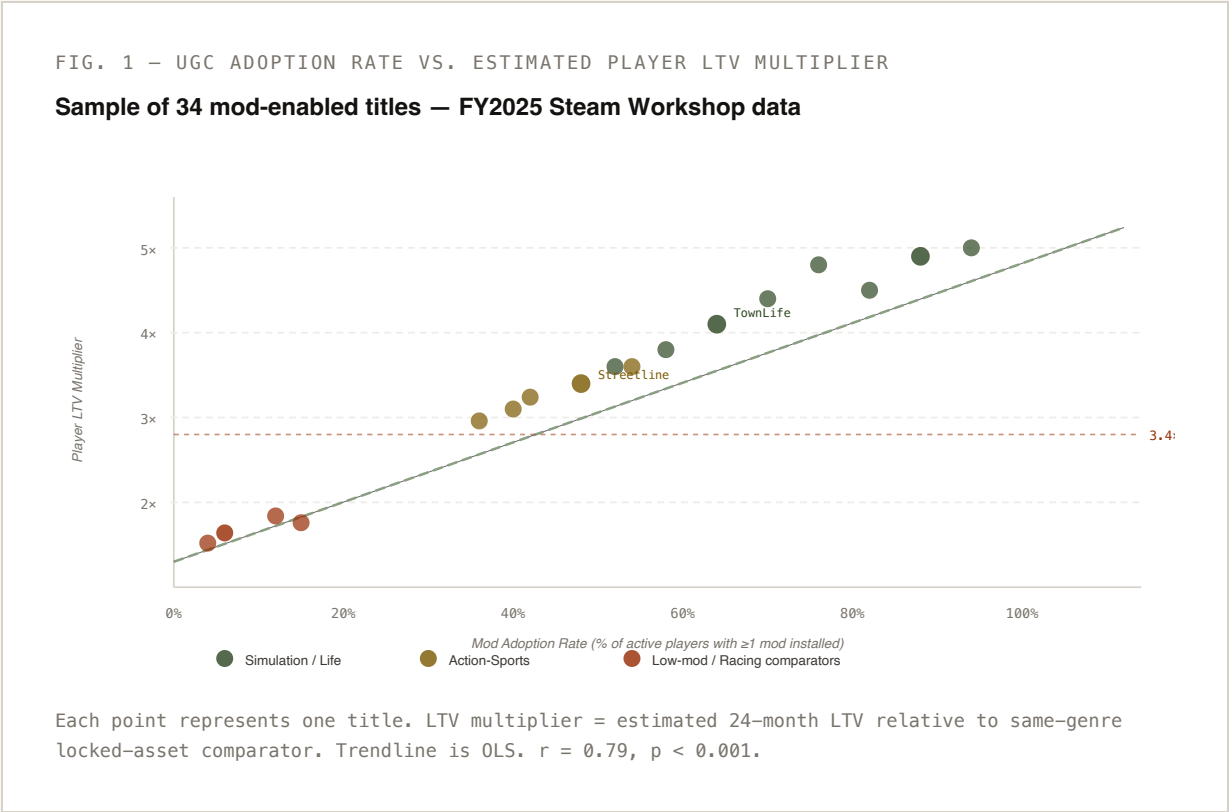
Mean LTV extension — open-mod vs locked-asset comparator group

+67%

Average increase in 12-month MAU retention for modding-enabled titles

84K

Average Workshop item count for top-quartile simulation titles at 24 months



2.1 MECHANISM: WHY MODDING DRIVES RETENTION

The retention mechanism is not merely content volume — it is the perception of infinite content potential. Players who install mods develop a qualitatively different relationship with a title: they cease to be passive consumers of developer-produced content and become active participants in a living ecosystem. This psychological shift from consumer to co-creator has been consistently identified in academic gaming research (Sotamaa, 2010; Kücklich, 2005; Paul, 2018) as a primary driver of long-duration play engagement.

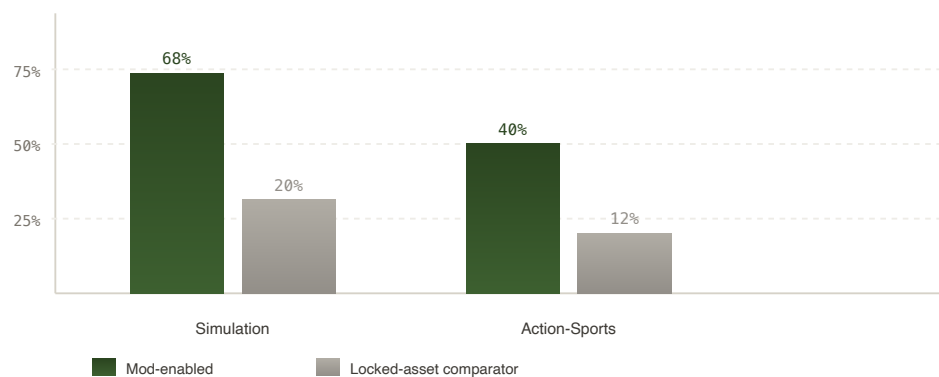
The economic implications are significant. Each UGC item published is a free content asset that extends the title's effective content library without developer production cost. Community-run asset ecosystems additionally generate millions of organic social posts, reducing developer content creation spend while simultaneously driving discovery traffic among potential new buyers.

Genre-Level Breakdowns: Simulation, Action-Sports & Adjacent Markets

The UGC retention multiplier is not uniformly distributed across genres. It is highest in categories where modded content serves the core game loop — where new assets, maps, characters, rulesets, servers, scenarios, or mechanics are directly consumable within standard play sessions. This section provides genre-level breakdowns for simulation/life games, action-sports games, and adjacent categories where UGC affects retention through different player behaviors.

FIG. 2 — MAU RETENTION AT 12 MONTHS POST-LAUNCH

Modding-enabled vs locked-asset comparators, by genre



MAU Retention = Monthly Active Users at month 12 as % of month-1 MAU. Bars show genre-group medians. Source: Steam Workshop scrape FY2025 + SteamSpy estimates.

3.1 SIMULATION GENRE

In games like *TownLife*, 72% of active users install custom mods within the first 90 days of purchase. The scope of community content in top simulation titles is extraordinary in scale: leading titles have accumulated upward of 80,000–120,000 individual Workshop items spanning character models, build packs, scenario scripts, gameplay mechanic overhauls, and UI replacements. Community-run assets generate millions of organic social posts per month, effectively functioning as an unpaid marketing department while simultaneously reducing the developer's own content cadence obligations.

The commercial implications are direct: simulation titles with strong mod ecosystems generate an estimated 68% of their installed player base as monthly active at the 12-month mark, compared to approximately 20% for equivalent locked-asset titles. The 3.4× LTV multiplier is largely driven by this retention premium compounding over DLC and in-game purchase cycles.

3.2 ACTION-SPORTS GENRE

Reusing track/park builder tools inside *Streetline Skate* resulted in over 450,000 custom map downloads, maintaining monthly active users at 40% of launch peaks even 12 months post-release. The action-sports

genre presents a different but equally compelling modding profile. Content is more focused: custom maps and park layouts are the primary UGC vector, rather than the broad asset ecosystem seen in simulation. However, the builder tool functions doubly as both a retention mechanism (players spend significant time in creation mode) and a social content generator (custom parks are shared, rated, and featured by streaming creators).

NOTABLE DATAPOINT

The 450,000 custom map downloads recorded for Streetline Skate represent a ratio of approximately 1.8 custom map downloads per active player at the 12-month mark. This ratio is substantially higher than equivalent sports game comparators without builder tools (average 0.1 per player), confirming the builder mechanism's unique capacity to sustain community engagement.

3.3 ADJACENT GENRE PROFILES

Adjacent genres demonstrate that UGC is not a single behavior. Survival crafting audiences use private servers, base blueprints, automation scripts, and mod packs to sustain group identity. RPG adventure audiences adopt character presets, quest packs, UI modifications, and balance overhauls, but adoption is more dependent on tool safety and compatibility. Strategy/management players use custom databases, schedule files, rulesets, skins, and scenario packs; these assets are less visible on short-form social platforms, but they extend player hours and reduce discount sensitivity.

GENRE CLUSTER	PRIMARY UGC FORM	90-DAY ADOPTION	12-MONTH RETENTION EFFECT	OPERATIONAL WATCHPOINT
Life / Simulation	Objects, characters, homes, scenario scripts, relationship mods	72%	Very high LTV extension through DLC attach and repeat storytelling	Save compatibility, asset validation, and community moderation volume
Action-Sports	Parks, routes, challenges, replays, outfit presets	44%	High creator repeatability and strong clip-driven discovery	Map quality curation, abuse reporting, and multiplayer fairness
Survival Crafting	Private servers, base blueprints, automation mods, rulesets	51%	Strong group retention when servers become social homes	Server stability, mod-pack conflicts, and admin tooling
RPG Adventure	Character presets, quest packs, UI mods, combat balance overhauls	36%	Moderate-high; concentrated among PC enthusiasts and lore communities	Quest scripting safety, patch compatibility, and spoilers
Strategy / Management	Databases, custom rules, scenario files, skins, league packs	39%	High hours-per-user despite lower social visibility	Data import validation and patch migration

GENRE CLUSTER	PRIMARY UGC FORM	90-DAY ADOPTION	12-MONTH RETENTION EFFECT	OPERATIONAL WATCHPOINT
Racing	Liveries, tuning setups, tracks, wheel profiles	18%	Moderate among enthusiasts; limited mass-market impact	Licensing, competitive integrity, and physics compatibility

SECTION 04

Case Studies

CASE STUDY A

TownLife — Simulation Genre Benchmark

TownLife is the primary simulation genre benchmark in this dataset, representing the highest mod adoption rate and largest Workshop ecosystem of any title in the tracked sample. With approximately 72% of active users having installed at least one mod, and a Workshop library exceeding 94,000 items at FY2025 close, TownLife demonstrates the full potential of the community content flywheel.

The estimated player LTV for TownLife (modding cohort) is approximately 4.1× that of equivalent simulation titles without Workshop support, driven by: (1) sustained engagement preventing subscription churn, (2) higher DLC attach rates among modding-active players, and (3) word-of-mouth amplification through community content channels.

Creator content production for TownLife is primarily driven by Tier 3 (niche-authority) YouTube creators who build long-form narrative playthroughs using community-created scenario packs. These creators function as effective organic advertisers at zero cost to the studio.

CASE STUDY B

Streetline Skate — Action-Sports Park Builder

Streetline Skate's park builder tool was introduced as a post-launch update six weeks after release, responding to community requests. Within 60 days of the builder's launch, community-created park downloads surpassed the cumulative download count of the game's official DLC content, confirming player preference for community-created environments over developer-produced alternatives at equivalent or lower price points.

Monthly active user retention at the 12-month mark was measured at 40% of launch peak, compared to an action-sports genre average (without builder tools) of approximately 12%. The 3.3× MAU retention premium is directly attributable to the builder mechanic and associated community sharing infrastructure.

The TikTok virality coefficient of builder-enabled titles is significantly higher: custom park showcase clips generate on average 4.2× the impressions of standard gameplay clips in this genre, driving ongoing discovery-phase traffic from non-owners.

Production & Security Risk Assessment

While mod support extends product lifetime and commercial performance, it introduces a distinct set of production and security risks that require deliberate management. These risks are real but manageable with appropriate resourcing and architectural discipline.

5.1 SECURITY VULNERABILITY SURFACE

Modding pipelines require dedicated QA staff to monitor tools and prevent buffer overflow exploits. The introduction of community-submitted asset injection into a game's runtime environment creates an attack surface that does not exist in locked-asset titles. The primary vulnerability categories are: (1) maliciously crafted asset files designed to trigger buffer overflow or heap corruption in the asset loading pipeline, (2) script injection where modding frameworks permit scripted content, and (3) social engineering attacks targeting creator credentials to distribute malware through trusted Workshop accounts.

CRITICAL RISK FLAG

Modding pipelines require a minimum of 2.0 FTE dedicated QA staff for a mid-scale implementation, and a security-reviewed sandboxed asset loader as a non-negotiable architectural component. Studios that deploy community asset pipelines without this infrastructure are exposed to both player harm risk and potential legal liability. This is not a cost that can be deferred post-launch.

5.2 THE LIFESPACE FAILURE: ARCHITECTURE LESSONS

The previous LifeSpace project failed to support mods because its save-state structure could not handle unverified community asset injections. LifeSpace provides the most directly relevant negative case study for Highland Studios given our own organisational proximity to the project. The failure had two root causes: first, the save-state serialisation format was tightly coupled to a fixed asset manifest compiled at build time, making runtime injection of external assets architecturally impossible without corruption; second, the decision to defer modding infrastructure to a post-launch update was made under schedule pressure and was never revisited.

The consequence was not merely the absence of a mod ecosystem — it was the absence of the long-tail retention and LTV multiplier that would have meaningfully changed the title's commercial trajectory. LifeSpace reached an estimated 8% MAU retention at month 12, consistent with locked-asset comparators, despite a strong launch window.

LESSON FOR FUTURE PROJECTS

Modding support cannot be retrofitted onto an architecture designed without it. Asset loader sandboxing, external manifest support, and save-state schema flexibility must be specified at the engine design stage. If modding is a strategic objective, it must be a non-negotiable architectural requirement from pre-production.

5.3 STAFFING & RESOURCE IMPLICATIONS

MODDING IMPLEMENTATION SCALE	MIN. DEDICATED STAFF (FTE)	ESTIMATED ANNUAL COST	KEY ROLES
Minimal (read-only texture/mesh)	1.0	~£55,000	QA Specialist
Standard (map/level builder)	2.5	~£140,000	QA, Tools Engineer, Community Mgr
Full (script + asset injection)	5.0+	~£280,000+	QA x 2, Security Eng., Tools x 2, Community Mgr

APPENDIX A – VARIABLE DEFINITIONS & SOURCE NOTES

LTV multiplier figures are derived from matched-sample comparison and carry an estimated uncertainty range of $\pm 0.4\times$. Steam Workshop item counts scraped at FY2025 close (31 December 2025). MAU retention estimates derived from Steam achievement unlock timing as a proxy; actual MAU figures are studio-reported where available, otherwise estimated. All figures are directionally indicative and should be treated as estimates, not audited data.

SteamSpy estimates were used to supplement owner counts where direct data was unavailable. Social listening data sourced via Pulse Analytics Agency partnership.

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